

Engineering Onboarding Guide

Northwind Analytics Ltd · NW-ENG-001 · Revision 8 · Classification: Internal

1. Your first week

This guide covers what a new engineer at Northwind Analytics needs in order to be productive. It is written on the assumption that you are competent and new, which is a different thing from being inexperienced.

Nobody expects a commit on day one. The expectation for week one is that you can build and run the platform locally, that you know who to ask about what, and that you have asked at least one question that felt obvious. The last of those is the important one.

2. Access and accounts

Your manager raises access requests before your start date. On day one you should have: an identity provider account with MFA enrolled, a laptop enrolled in device management, repository access to your team's projects, and read access to the staging environment.

Production access is not granted at onboarding. It is granted after you have completed the security induction, shipped changes through the normal pipeline, and been on-call shadow for one rotation. This is not a statement about you; it is how least privilege works and it applies to everyone including the CTO.

Set up the password manager before anything else. Storing a credential in a note file, a browser profile, or a repository is the single most common policy breach and it is avoidable in the first hour.

3. Development environment

Everything runs locally. Clone the platform repository, run the bootstrap script, and you will have PostgreSQL, the object store emulator, and the API running under Docker Compose. The bootstrap script is idempotent; running it twice is safe.

If the bootstrap script fails, that is a defect in the script, not in your machine. Raise it. Onboarding friction is invisible to everyone who onboarded before the thing broke, so the only person who can report it is you, and only during your first week.

4. How we ship

Trunk-based development with short-lived branches. A branch that lives longer than three days is a signal that the change is too large, not that the reviewer is slow.

Every change requires one approving review. Reviews are expected within one working day. A review comment is a question until proven otherwise, and the author is free to disagree with any of them and say why.

CI runs unit tests, integration tests, type checking, linting, dependency audit, and container scanning. A red build is never merged, and 'the test is flaky' is a defect to be fixed rather than a reason to re-run.

Deployment to production is automatic on merge to main, behind feature flags. A change that cannot be flagged is a change that needs a deployment plan, agreed before it starts.

5. Testing expectations

Write the test that would have caught the bug. Coverage percentage is reported but is not a target; a suite at 95% that tests only the happy path is worse than one at 70% that tests the failure modes, because it produces false confidence.

Integration tests run against real dependencies in containers, not mocks. Mocks are for unit tests and for third-party services we do not control.

A passing test suite proves the pieces behave. It does not prove the system works. Before calling a change done, run it and use it as a user would.

6. On-call

Engineers join the on-call rotation after approximately three months, starting as a shadow for one full rotation. The rotation is one week in six and is compensated.

You are never expected to resolve an incident alone. Escalating is the correct action and carries no stigma whatsoever. The person who escalates at 03:00 after fifteen minutes is doing the job properly; the person who struggles alone until 06:00 is not.

After any incident you were involved in, you will be asked to contribute to a blameless review. Say what you actually saw and what you actually did, including anything that turned out to be wrong. That is where the value is.

7. Security expectations for engineers

Treat every input as untrusted, including from internal systems and including from a document a user uploaded. Validate at the boundary and encode at the point of use.

Never commit a secret. If you do, rotate it immediately and tell Security Operations. Rewriting history does not make an exposed credential safe, because you cannot know who cloned the repository before you rewrote it.

Where you work on retrieval-augmented or agentic features, remember that anyone who can add a document to a corpus can influence what the model does. Retrieved content is data, never instruction, and it must be delimited as such in every prompt you construct.

8. Asking for help

The team channel is the default. A question asked in the open helps the next person and is searchable; the same question in a direct message helps one person once.

There is no waiting period before asking. The convention is roughly thirty minutes of genuine effort, then ask, describing what you tried. Nobody is measuring.

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